Percy Siganporia, who succeeded Khusrokhan as MD, further added that Tata Tea would look at new opportunities in different markets. The company had a presence only in '35 per cent of the tea consuming market', and it left considerable space for the company to expand. In 2005, Krishna Kumar reiterated the company's pursuit of foreign acquisitions and outlined a 'two-forked acquisition strategy', 'planning to take over a company along with its brand in North or South America' and also 'preparing to acquire mid-sized companies in the US and Latin America'. He added that the first could be 'larger than the Tetley buyout'.

Continuing its buying spree, Tata Tea acquired the US-based fruit and herbal tea brand, Good Earth, through its US-based subsidiary, Tetley US Holdings. Simultaneously, the company also focused on restructuring itself by reducing its interests in plantations and focusing on the branded tea business, which contributed to over 80 per cent of the company's turnover.

Ratan said that 'keeping in mind the volatility of plantation operations', Tata Tea had decided to initiate a 'number of steps to reduce costs, improve productivity and quality and eliminate wasteful expenditure'. Pursuing this policy, an attempt was made to transfer the ownership of the tea estates to a company that would be run through a participatory architecture with the employees playing a supporting role. Ratan was hopeful that this 'unique model primarily based on employee-ownership' would allow the employees 'with their entrepreneurial skill' to 'create wealth for the company and for themselves'. While the strategy succeeded to some extent in Munnar, it had only marginal success in the Northeast, as the employees did not have the resources to take over the management as it involved high stakes, says Siganporia.

In 2006, Tata Coffee acquired the US-based Eight O'Clock Coffee brand for $220 million. Tata Tea, along with Tata Sons, also acquired a 30 per cent stake in Glacéau Vitaminwater (Energy Brands Inc.), a US-based enhanced water maker, for $677 million.

**Ambitious Plans**

Just as he had thought big for other companies, Ratan also had plans for Tata Consumer Products. At the 2006 AGM, he declared that Tata Tea was 'gearing [up] to grow its operations' size from the current Rs 3,151 crore to Rs 7,000 crore in the next three years'. Krishna Kumar also unveiled the